

أَعُوذُ بِاللَّهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيمِ

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Lisan ul Quran — Lecture 9

Wus'at · Ma'rifah and Nakirah

1. The third aspect of the Ism: Wus'at

Four things must be known about any *Ism* used in Arabic, without which the word can neither be understood nor placed in a sentence: its gender, its number, its *wus'at*, and its *I'raab*. The subject of this lecture is the third of these, *wus'at* — whether a noun is *Ma'rifah* or *Nakirah*.

2. The categories of the Ism by Wus'at

Category	Definition	Examples
Ism Nakirah	A common noun — one that denotes something indefinite	كِتَابٌ ، قَلَمٌ ، كُرْسِيٌّ
Ism Ma'rifah	A particular noun — one that denotes something definite	زَيْدٌ ، هُوَ ، غُلَامٌ زَيْدٍ

The *Ism Nakirah* is wider in scope, whereas the compass of the *Ism Ma'rifah* is limited.

The governing principle: Every *Ism* used in Arabic is counted as *Nakirah* until it is established as *Ma'rifah*.

The two kinds of Ism Nakirah

- *Nakirah Makhsusah* — a *Nakirah* that has been made specific by some means of specification, for instance by attaching an adjective or by annexing it to another *Nakirah*, as in *طِفْلٌ رَجُلٍ* and *رَجُلٌ عَالِمٌ*.
- *Nakirah Ghayr Makhsusah* — a *Nakirah* not made specific by any means at all, as in *كِتَابٌ*.

3. The seven categories of Ma'rifah

Arabic has seven categories of *Ma'rifah*. The first five are dealt with in this lecture, and the last two will follow later.

#	Category	Definition	Example
1	Ism ul 'Alam	A noun coined for one particular person, place or thing	زَيْدٌ ، مَرْيَمٌ ، مَكَّةُ
2	Ism ud Dameer	A noun denoting the speaker, the addressee or the absent one	أَنَا ، أَنْتَ ، هُوَ
3	Ism ul Isharah	A noun by which one points to something definite	هَذَا ، ذَلِكَ
4	Ism ul Mawsul	A noun that becomes part of the speech by joining the clause after it	الَّذِي ، الَّتِي
5	Mu'arraaf bil Lam	A noun with the Lam ut Ta'reef at its beginning	الْكِتَابُ ، الرَّجُلُ
6	Mu'arraaf bil Idafah	A noun annexed to one of the five categories above	غُلَامُهُ
7	Mu'arraaf bin Nida	A noun with a Harf un Nida at its beginning	يَا رَجُلُ

4. First category: Ism ul 'Alam

A'lam is the plural of *'alam*. An *Ism ul 'Alam* is the particular name of a person, place or thing — in English, a proper noun, that is, a noun that stands as the name of one specific place, person or thing.

- زَيْدٌ — not everyone is named Zayd.
- مَرْيَمٌ — not every girl is named Maryam.
- مَكَّةُ — this is the name of one particular city; not every city is called Makkah.

5. Second category: Ism ud Dameer

Dama'ir is the plural of *dameer*. Nouns used in place of a name are called *dama'ir*. Rather than repeating the word Zayd again and again in a sentence, one says Zayd once and thereafter uses he, him and his — and in Arabic the *dama'ir* serve exactly this purpose.

The three kinds of Dama'ir

English term	Meaning	Arabic name
First Person	the one speaking	Mutakallim
Second Person	the one spoken to	Mukhatab or Hadir
Third Person	the one spoken about	Gha'ib

The complete table of the Dameer Marfoo' Munfasil

A *dameer* that occurs in the position of *raf'* and is not joined to its governing word is called a *Dameer Marfoo' Munfasil*. It is used most often as a *Mubtada*, a *Khabar*, a *Fa'il* or a *Na'ib ul Fa'il*. Its fourteen forms are these:

Dameer	Its use
هُوَ	singular masculine Gha'ib
هُمَا	dual masculine Gha'ib
هُمْ	plural masculine Gha'ib
هِيَ	singular feminine Gha'ib
هُمَا	dual feminine Gha'ib
هُنَّ	plural feminine Gha'ib
أَنْتَ	singular masculine Hadir
أَنْتُمَا	dual masculine Hadir
أَنْتُمْ	plural masculine Hadir
أَنْتِ	singular feminine Hadir
أَنْتُمَا	dual feminine Hadir
أَنْتُنَّ	plural feminine Hadir
أَنَا	singular Mutakallim, masculine and feminine alike
نَحْنُ	dual and plural Mutakallim, masculine and feminine alike

6. Third category: Ism ul Isharah

Asma' ul Isharah are the nouns coined for pointing to something. The thing pointed to is called the *Mushar Ilayh*. In هَذَا الْقَلَمُ نَفِيسٌ (this pen is precious), هَذَا is the *Ism ul Isharah* and الْقَلَمُ the *Mushar Ilayh*. It is required that the *Mushar Ilayh* be visible and perceptible; if the pointing is to something imperceptible, the usage is figurative.

Urdu and English use one word for what is near and another for what is far. Arabic, being a wide language, has separate *asma' ul isharah* for the singular masculine, the singular feminine, the dual and the plural, and for the near and the far alike.

Form	For what is near	For what is far	Meaning
singular masculine	هَذَا	ذَلِكَ	this / that one man
dual masculine	هَذَانِ ، هَذَيْنِ	ذَانِكَ ، ذَيْنِكَ	these / those two men
plural masculine	هَؤُلَاءِ	أُولَئِكَ	these / those people
singular feminine	هَذِهِ	تِلْكَ	this / that one woman
dual feminine	هَاتَانِ ، هَاتَيْنِ	تَانِكَ ، تَيْنِكَ	these / those two women
plural feminine	هَؤُلَاءِ	أُولَئِكَ	these / those women

The three degrees of pointing

The rule of recognition: If an *Ism ul Isharah* is free of both a lam and a kaf, it is for what is near, as in هَذَا ، هَذَانِ. If a kaf alone comes at its end, it is for the middle distance, as in ذَاكَ ، ذَيْنِكَ ، ذَانِكَ. And if both a lam and a kaf come at its end, it is for what is far, as in ذَٰلِكَ ، ذَٰلِكُمَا.

Pointing to a place

- هُنَا ، هَهُنَا — here, pointing to a near place
- هُنَاكَ — there, pointing to a place at middle distance
- هُنَاكَ — there, pointing to a distant place

A rule of construction: If an *Ism Nakirah* comes after an *Ism ul Isharah*, the *Ism ul Isharah* becomes the *Mubtada* and the *Ism Nakirah* the *Khabar*, as in هَذَا كِتَابٌ (this is a book).

7. Fourth category: Ism ul Mawsul

Nouns that serve to join words or clauses are called *Asma' ul Mawsulah*. Urdu uses jo, jis, jin and jinhen for this purpose, and English uses which, that and who.

In terminology the *Asma' ul Mawsulah* are nouns that cannot form part of the speech on their own, but become part of it by joining the clause that follows them. That clause is called the *Silah*.

In جَاءَ الَّذِي نَصَرَنِي (the one who helped me came), الَّذِي is the *Ism ul Mawsul* and the whole *jumla fi'liyyah* نَصَرَنِي is its *Silah*. الَّذِي alone cannot form part of the speech.

For the Mudhakkar

Halat ur Raf'	Halat un Nasb wal Jarr	Meaning	Form
الَّذِي	الَّذِي	he who, or him who	singular masculine
الَّذَانِ	الَّذَيْنِ	the two who	dual masculine
الَّذِينَ	الَّذِينَ	those who	plural masculine
الَّذِي	الَّذِي	those who	plural masculine

For the Mu'annath

Halat ur Raf'	Halat un Nasb wal Jarr	Meaning	Form
الَّتِي	الَّتِي	she who, or her who	singular feminine
الَّتَانِ	الَّتَيْنِ	the two who	dual feminine
الَّتِي	الَّتِي	those who	plural feminine
الَّتِي	الَّتِي	those who	plural feminine

For the Mudhakkar and Mu'annath alike

Ism ul Mawsul	Meaning	For what
مَنْ	he who, or him who	singular, dual and plural, masculine and feminine alike
مَا	that which, or what	singular, dual and plural, masculine and feminine alike
أَيُّ ، أَيَّةُ	whoever, whichever	singular, dual and plural, masculine and feminine alike
ال (in the sense of الَّذِي of	the one who	when it enters upon an Ism ul Fa'il or an Ism ul Maf'ul

الَّذِي and أَلَيْ both appear very frequently in the Qur'an.

8. Fifth category: Mu'arraḥ bil Lam

To turn a *Nakirah* into a *Ma'rifah*, a lam is placed at its beginning, and such a *Ma'rifah* noun is called *Mu'arraḥ bil Lam*. Since that lam is silent, the word cannot be pronounced, so an additional hamzah carrying a fathah is placed before it. That hamzah is called the *Hamzat ul Wasl*.

The two parts of al-

- In *أل* the hamzah is called the *Hamzat ul Wasl*.
- In *أل* the lam is called the *Lam ut Ta'reef*.
- It is this lam that turns an *Ism Nakirah* into an *Ism Ma'rifah*.
- The *Hamzat ul Wasl* always carries a fathah.
- The Arabic *أل* corresponds to the English article the.

So *ألشَّمْسُ* gives *الشَّمْسُ*, *أَلْحَمْدُ* gives *الْحَمْدُ*, and *أَلْمُسْلِمُ* gives *الْمُسْلِمُ*.

An essential rule: Once *alif lam* enters a noun, no *Tanween* can come at its end; the two marks cannot occur together. Accordingly *أل* is called the *Harfut Ta'reef* and the *Tanween* the *Harfut Tankeer*. One therefore says either *طَاوِلَةٌ* or *طَاوِلَةً*.

Why it is called the Hamzat ul Wasl

When the *Hamzat ul Wasl* is joined to what comes before it, its vowel is not pronounced and the hamzah remains written merely as an alif. This is why it is called the *Hamzat ul Wasl*, the hamzah of joining, as in *وَالْحَمْدُ* and *ذَلِكَ الْكِتَابُ*.

Recognising it in the Saudi Mushaf: In the Saudi *Mushaf* the *Hamzat ul Wasl* is very easy to spot: if a small *ص* is written above the alif, that hamzah is a *Hamzat ul Wasl*.

Sometimes the lam is pronounced and sometimes it is not

The lam of *أل* is sometimes articulated and sometimes merely written without being sounded. In *أَلْقَمَرِ* the lam is pronounced, but in *أَلشَّمْسِ* it is not. The matter is decided by the first letter of the *Nakirah* noun, and on this basis the *Huroof ul Hijaa'* are divided into two classes.

Qamari letters

The first letter of nouns on which the lam of *أل* is pronounced is called a *Qamari* letter. There are fourteen of them:

ا	ب	ج	ح	خ	ع	غ
ف	ق	ك	م	و	هـ	ي

The well-known sentence for memorising them is: **إِنِغِ حَجَّكَ وَخَفْ عَقِيمَهُ**

Nakirah	Ma'rifah	Nakirah	Ma'rifah
حَقَّ	الْحَقُّ	وَزُنْ	الْوَزْنُ
قَدَّرْ	الْقَدَرُ	فُوزْ	الْفَوْزُ
كِتَابْ	الْكِتَابُ	عَدَلْ	الْعَدْلُ
أَنْهَارْ	الْأَنْهَارُ	جَبَالَ	الْجِبَالُ
خَوْفْ	الْخَوْفُ	غُلَامْ	الْغُلَامُ
هُدًى	الْهُدًى	مَوْتْ	الْمَوْتُ
بَيْتْ	الْبَيْتُ	يَتِيمْ	الْيَتِيمُ

Shamsi letters

The first letter of nouns on which the lam of **أَلْ** is not pronounced is called a **Shamsi** letter. In such a case, instead of the lam the following letter is doubled, as in **الرَّسُولُ** ، **الرَّكُوعُ** ، **الشَّيْطَانُ** . These too are fourteen:

س	ز	ر	ذ	د	ث	ت
ن	ل	ظ	ط	ض	ص	ش

Nakirah	Ma'rifah	Nakirah	Ma'rifah
سَبِيلْ	السَّبِيلُ	سَبِيلْ	السَّبِيلُ
نَمَرَاتْ	النَّمَرَاتُ	نَمَرَاتْ	النَّمَرَاتُ
ذِكْرْ	الذِّكْرُ	ذِكْرْ	الذِّكْرُ

Nakirah	Ma'rifah	Nakirah	Ma'rifah
زَكَاةً	الرَّكَاةَ	شَمْسٍ	الشَّمْسِ
صَبْرٍ	الصَّبْرَ	طَيْرٍ	الطَّيْرِ
لَيْلٍ	اللَّيْلَ	ضَالِّينَ	الضَّالِّينَ
ظَالِمُونَ	الظَّالِمُونَ	نَجْمٍ	النَّجْمِ

إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَأْمُرُ بِالْعَدْلِ وَالْإِحْسَانِ وَإِيتَاءِ ذِي الْقُرْبَىٰ وَيَنْهَىٰ عَنِ الْفَحْشَاءِ وَالْمُنْكَرِ وَالْبَغْيِ ۚ يَعِظُكُم لَعَلَّكُمْ تَذَكَّرُونَ

(Surah an-Nahl: 90)

Translation: Indeed Allah commands justice and excellence and giving to relatives, and He forbids immorality, wrongdoing and oppression. He admonishes you so that you may take heed.

9. The two senses of al-

The Arabic **أَلْ** corresponds to the English article the. Just as the cow in English may mean one particular cow or the whole species, so in Arabic **الْإِنْسَانُ** may mean one specific human being or the whole of humankind. On this basis **أَلْ** can carry two kinds of meaning.

9.1 The first sense: all or every — al-Istighraq

The word *istighraq* is derived from the Arabic root غ . ر . ق , whose meanings are to drown, to immerse, or to encompass something entirely. For a thing to sink in water in such a way that no part of it remains outside is called *istighraq*.

The technical definition: It is that *alif lam* which encompasses all the individuals and particulars of its *madkhul* — the noun it enters upon. That is, every individual of that noun's genus becomes included in the ruling. An **أَلْ** from which the sense of "all" or "every" may be taken is called, in grammar, *al-Istighraq* or *Lam ul Istighraq*.

الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ رَبِّ الْعَالَمِينَ

(Surah al-Fatihah: 2)

Translation: All praise belongs to Allah, the Lord of all the worlds.

This does not mean that some particular praise belongs to Allah, for when a *Nakirah* becomes a *Ma'rifah* a specific sense arises. Here the **أَلْ** is conveying the sense of "all".

إِنَّ الْإِنْسَانَ لِفِي خُسْرٍ

(Surah al-'Asr: 2)

Translation: Indeed every human being is in loss. Indeed man is in loss through and through.

If this were translated as though some particular human being were in loss, the correct sense would not emerge. The **أل** that has entered **الإنسان** therefore carries the sense of "all" or "every".

Whether "all" or "every" is intended in a given place is known from the context.

9.2 The second sense: making a noun specific

The second sense is that in which **أل** turns an *Ism Nakirah* into an *Ism Ma'rifah*, that is, makes it specific. In English a book means one book or some book, whereas the book means one particular book. In grammatical terminology this **أل** is called the *Lam ul 'Ahd*, the lam that points to something already known or determined.

How the decision is made: Whether an **أل** in a given place is for *istighraq* or for *'ahd* is always decided by the **context**. The outward form of the word is identical in both cases.

A Nakirah conveying magnitude or insignificance

Sometimes in Arabic a *Nakirah* noun can itself convey something very great or very slight. The word **خُسْرٍ** means loss or harm. When it is used as a *Nakirah*, one point of *fasahah* and *balaghah* is that the loss meant may be an enormous one or a trifling one. Here too the context decides.

In Surah al-'Asr Allah swears an oath and then states that man is in loss. To swear an oath in order to announce some trifling loss is not the intent; what is meant is a very great and far-reaching loss. This is why the translation also renders it as loss through and through.

قُلْ إِنَّ هُدَى اللَّهِ هُوَ الْهُدَى

(Surah al-Baqarah: 120)

Translation: Say: indeed the guidance of Allah is the true guidance.

Summary

1. The third aspect of the Ism is wus'at, that is, whether it is Ma'rifah or Nakirah.
2. A Nakirah denotes something indefinite and a Ma'rifah denotes something definite.
3. The Nakirah is wider in scope and the Ma'rifah narrower. Every noun counts as Nakirah until it is established as Ma'rifah.
4. The Nakirah is of two kinds: Nakirah Makhsusah and Nakirah Ghayr Makhsusah.
5. There are seven categories of Ma'rifah: Ism ul 'Alam, Ism ud Dameer, Ism ul Isharah, Ism ul Mawsul, Mu'arraḥ bil Lam, Mu'arraḥ bil Idafah and Mu'arraḥ bin Nida.
6. An Ism ul 'Alam is the particular name of a person, place or thing, as in مَكَّةَ, زَيْدٌ, مَرْيَمَ.
7. The Dama'ir are of three kinds: Mutakallim, Mukhatab or Hadir, and Gha'ib.
8. The Dameer Marfoo' Munfasil has fourteen forms, from هُوَ through to نَحْنُ.
9. An Ism ul Isharah points to something, and the thing pointed to is called the Mushar Ilayh.
10. An Isharah free of lam and kaf is for what is near, one with a kaf alone for the middle distance, and one with both lam and kaf for what is far.
11. For places the words are هُنَا, هُنَاكَ and هُنَالِكَ.
12. An Ism ul Mawsul cannot form part of the speech alone; it does so by joining the clause after it, which is called the Silah.
13. الَّذِي is for the Mudhakkar and الَّتِي for the Mu'annath, while مَنْ, مَا and أَيُّ serve for both.
14. In اَلْ the hamzah is the Hamzat ul Wasl and the lam is the Lam ut Ta'reef; it is the lam that makes a noun Ma'rifah.
15. The Hamzat ul Wasl always carries a fathah, and when joined to a preceding word its vowel is not pronounced. In the Saudi Mushaf a small ص is written above it.
16. Alif lam and Tanween cannot occur together: alif lam is Harf ut Ta'reef and Tanween is Harf ut Tankeer.
17. There are fourteen Qamari letters, on which the lam is pronounced. The well-known sentence for them is اِبْنُ حَجَّكَ وَخَفَّ عَقِيْمُهُ.
18. There are likewise fourteen Shamsi letters, on which the lam is not pronounced but the following letter is doubled.
19. The root of istighraq is غ ر ق, whose meaning is to encompass something entirely.
20. The Lam ul Istighraq is that al- which encompasses all the individuals and particulars of its madkhul, as in اَلْاِنْسَانُ and اَلْحَمْدُ.
21. The second al- is the one that makes a Nakirah specific, and it is called the Lam ul 'Ahd.
22. The decision between the two is always made from the context, since the form of the word stays the same.
23. A Nakirah noun can also carry a very great or a very slight sense according to the context, as خُسْرٌ does in Surah al-'Asr.

Exercise

1. What is meant by wus'at? Define Ma'rifah and Nakirah with examples.
 2. Explain the difference between Nakirah Makhsusah and Nakirah Ghayr Makhsusah.
 3. Name the seven categories of Ma'rifah and give one example of each.
 4. Define the Ism ul 'Alam and explain with three examples why these are particular names.
 5. Write the Arabic and English names of all three kinds of Dama'ir.
 6. Write the fourteen forms of the Dameer Marfoo' Munfasil in order.
 7. What is meant by Mushar Ilayh? Explain with an example.
 8. Write the rule for distinguishing the Isharah for what is near, for the middle distance and for what is far.
 9. Write four forms each of the Asma' ul Mawsulah for the Mudhakkar and for the Mu'annath.
 10. What is the Silah? Explain using جَاءَ الَّذِي نَصَرَنِي.
 11. Explain the difference between the Hamzat ul Wasl and the Lam ut Ta'reef, and state which of the two makes a noun Ma'rifah.
 12. Why is it named the Hamzat ul Wasl? Explain with a Qur'anic example.
 13. Write the Qamari and Shamsi letters separately, with three examples of each.
 14. Write the literal meaning and the technical definition of istighraq.
 15. What is the difference between the Lam ul Istighraq and the Lam ul 'Ahd, and on what basis is the decision made?
 16. What sense arises from خُسْرٍ being a Nakirah in the verse of Surah al-'Asr?
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سُبْحَانَكَ اللَّهُمَّ وَبِحَمْدِكَ، أَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا أَنْتَ، أَسْتَغْفِرُكَ وَأَتُوبُ إِلَيْكَ

اللَّهُمَّ صَلِّ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا صَلَّيْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ

اللَّهُمَّ بَارِكْ عَلَى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلَى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا بَارَكْتَ عَلَى إِبْرَاهِيمَ وَعَلَى آلِ إِبْرَاهِيمَ إِنَّكَ حَمِيدٌ مَجِيدٌ